

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Attitude: Content, Structure and Persuasion - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Attitude: Content, Structure and Persuasion

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 What attitude is: the ABC model and key distinctions

2 How attitudes form and change through experience and persuasion

3 Indian administrative applications of attitude and persuasion

4 Must-know facts for prelims on attitude and persuasion

5 Traps that cost marks in attitude questions

6 PYQ application: what the examiner actually tested

7 Mains angles and answer architecture for attitude questions

8 Selectable evidence units for attitude answers

9 Moral attitude versus political attitude in civil service

10 Directive decoding, study links, and consolidated revision

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A district official strongly favours a particular watershed programme but remains indifferent to an unrelated literacy drive. Which concept explains why her stance toward each programme differs despite her broad commitment to public welfare? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- B. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- C. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- D. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.

Answer: A **Explanation:** Attitude is object-specific, not a general life principle is the controlling principle. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A trainee declares honesty as a lifelong principle yet shows no evaluative stance toward a new digital-attendance system. Which distinction separates a cross-situational value from an object-directed attitude? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- B. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- C. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.
- D. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.

Answer: B **Explanation:** Attitude is object-specific, not a general life principle is the controlling principle. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates

across situations and is not tied to any single object. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A revenue officer believes that RTI requests increase workload and reduce efficiency. She has not yet developed resentment toward applicants. Which attitudinal component is currently engaged and which remains dormant? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- B. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- C. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- D. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.

Answer: C Explanation: The cognitive component carries beliefs, not feelings is the controlling principle. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A health inspector reads research showing that street-food vendors follow safe practices in most sampled cities. His factual beliefs change, but his emotional discomfort persists. Which two components are pulling in opposite directions? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- B. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.
- C. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- D. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.

Answer: D Explanation: The cognitive component carries beliefs, not feelings is the controlling principle. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

After attending a sensitisation workshop a block officer intellectually accepts that tribal applicants deserve equal service, yet continues to feel discomfort during face-to-face interactions. Which component explains the residual resistance? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- B. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- C. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- D. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.

Answer: A Explanation: The affective component carries emotional charge is the controlling principle. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A municipal engineer dislikes a community but cannot articulate any factual reason for the dislike. Which attitudinal component is dominant and which is weak or absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- B. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- C. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.
- D. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.

Answer: B Explanation: The affective component carries emotional charge is the controlling principle. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A sub-divisional magistrate privately intends to report a senior's misconduct but remains silent when the departmental meeting begins. Which concept explains the gap between intention and inaction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- B. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- C. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.
- D. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.

Answer: C Explanation: The behavioural component is a tendency, not a guarantee is the controlling principle. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

An officer who dislikes a transfer policy still complies because career incentives outweigh personal resistance. Which feature of the behavioural component does this illustrate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The cognitive component of attitude refers to the beliefs, knowledge and informational claims a person holds about the attitude object; it supplies the factual basis on which evaluative judgement rests and is distinct from the emotional charge that constitutes the affective component.
- B. The affective component of attitude is the emotional response, whether positive or negative, attached to the attitude object; it can persist even when new factual information contradicts the cognitive component, making training that targets only beliefs insufficient for durable attitude change.
- C. An attitude is a relatively stable evaluative disposition directed toward a specific object, person or idea, comprising cognitive, affective and behavioural components; it is narrower than a value, which operates across situations and is not tied to any single object.
- D. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap.

Answer: D Explanation: The behavioural component is a tendency, not a guarantee is the controlling principle. The behavioural or conative component of attitude is the predisposition to act in a certain way toward the attitude object; it does not guarantee actual behaviour because situational pressures, institutional incentives and social norms can override the predisposition and produce an attitude-behaviour gap. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A newly posted collector who grew up in a rural area readily trusts local panchayat leaders, whereas her predecessor from an urban background was skeptical. Which formation pathway best explains the divergence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- B. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- C. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- D. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.

Answer: A Explanation: Attitudes form through experience, learning and reinforcement is the controlling principle. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

An officer who is praised every time she clears files quickly develops a positive stance toward speed over thoroughness. Which formation mechanism is operating and what risk does it carry? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- B. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- C. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.
- D. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.

Answer: B Explanation: Attitudes form through experience, learning and reinforcement is the controlling principle. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A state vaccination campaign uses a respected local ASHA worker to deliver simplified messages in the vernacular language to hesitant parents. Which Hovland-Yale variables are being activated and which one is absent from the original model? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- B. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- C. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- D. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.

Answer: C Explanation: Hovland-Yale persuasion rests on source, message and audience is the controlling principle. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A central ministry issues a detailed technical circular on maternal health to illiterate beneficiaries through a formal gazette notification. Which persuasion variable has been ignored and why does the campaign likely fail? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- B. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.
- C. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- D. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.

Answer: D Explanation: Hovland-Yale persuasion rests on source, message and audience is the controlling principle. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

An officer who values transparency is directed to withhold a routine file under a stretched RTI exemption. She convinces herself the exemption is broader than it actually is. Which dissonance resolution path has she taken and why is it ethically risky? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- B. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- C. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- D. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.

Answer: A Explanation: Cognitive dissonance creates three resolution paths is the controlling principle. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A procurement officer accepts a first small gift and then reasons that everyone does it, so it must be acceptable. Which Festinger pathway explains how small compromises consolidate into settled corrupt practice? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- B. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- C. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.
- D. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.

Answer: B Explanation: Cognitive dissonance creates three resolution paths is the controlling principle. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

In an annual ethics survey, every officer in a revenue department declares commitment to transparency, yet RTI compliance rates remain below fifty per cent. Which concept explains the divergence and what institutional response is indicated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- B. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- C. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.
- D. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.

Answer: C Explanation: The attitude-behaviour gap shows that good attitudes are necessary but insufficient is the controlling principle. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A district training programme improves officers' pro-citizen attitudes but leaves the opaque manual approval system unchanged. Why might service-delivery improvements be temporary despite genuine attitude change? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Hovland-Yale attitude-change approach identifies the communicator's credibility, the message's content and framing, and the audience's predispositions as the three original persuasion variables; the channel or medium is a later addition from wider communication research and was not part of the original 1953 Yale triad.
- B. When behaviour contradicts a held attitude, cognitive dissonance produces psychological discomfort that can be resolved by changing the attitude to match behaviour, changing future behaviour to match the attitude, or adding a self-justifying cognition; the third path is the ethically dangerous one because it enables rationalisation of misconduct.
- C. Attitudes form through direct experience with an object, social learning from family, peers and media, and reinforcement through repeated positive or negative outcomes; their origin explains why two officials in the same office can hold opposite evaluations of the same beneficiary community.
- D. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour.

Answer: D Explanation: The attitude-behaviour gap shows that good attitudes are necessary but insufficient is the controlling principle. LaPiere's 1934 study demonstrated that a general stated attitude predicts a specific act poorly; institutional design through binding external constraints such as RTI mandates, whistleblower protection and audit trails exists precisely because attitude alone cannot guarantee consistent ethical behaviour. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A district administration runs a community-leader-led campaign with verified facts to change attitudes toward girl-child education. A neighbouring district uses fear-based imagery without disclosing government sponsorship. Which campaign crosses the persuasion-propaganda boundary and why? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- B. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- C. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- D. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.

Answer: A Explanation: Persuasion is ethically distinct from manipulation and propaganda is the controlling principle. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A social-media cell creates emotionally charged posts about a welfare scheme using undisclosed paid influencers and suppresses critical comments. Which ethical line has been crossed even though the underlying policy goal may be legitimate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- B. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- C. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.
- D. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.

Answer: B Explanation: Persuasion is ethically distinct from manipulation and propaganda is the controlling principle. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A political party uses voter data to send contradictory health-scheme messages to different demographic segments on the same day. Which Hovland-Yale variable has been transformed by digital technology and what ethical problem does this create? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- B. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- C. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- D. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.

Answer: C Explanation: Algorithmic targeting changes the audience variable at unprecedented scale is the controlling principle. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A state uses algorithmic recommendation to promote its vaccination campaign with transparent sponsorship labels and factual content. Does this cross the ethical boundary and what test determines the answer? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- B. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.
- C. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- D. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.

Answer: D Explanation: Algorithmic targeting changes the audience variable at unprecedented scale is the controlling principle. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A gram panchayat uses wall paintings with local-language facts about handwashing benefits, names the sponsoring ministry, and invites questions at weekly meetings. Which persuasion criteria make this ethically defensible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- B. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- C. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- D. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.

Answer: A Explanation: Legitimate government campaigns rest on truthfulness and non-coercion is the controlling principle. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A block administration withholds ration cards from families that refuse to attend a sanitation rally. Even though the sanitation goal is legitimate, which ethical condition has been violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- B. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- C. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.
- D. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.

Answer: B Explanation: Legitimate government campaigns rest on truthfulness and non-coercion is the controlling principle. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A health ministry uses short videos with doctor endorsements and sponsorship labels to counter vaccine misinformation, while a private network spreads deepfake testimonials on the same platform. Which factor distinguishes the two ethically? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- B. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- C. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.
- D. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.

Answer: C Explanation: The same digital channel enables both legitimate persuasion and disinformation is the controlling principle. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A state bans all social-media health communication to prevent misinformation, thereby also blocking verified government advisories. Which ethical nuance has the blanket ban missed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Social-media platforms operationalise persuasion variables at a scale the Hovland-Yale model did not anticipate: the audience variable is now algorithmically segmented through micro-targeting, which can shade legitimate persuasion into manipulation by exploiting individual cognitive biases invisible to the audience itself.
- B. Public information campaigns such as financial literacy drives, sanitation behaviour change under Swachh Bharat, and digital-payment adoption are legitimate state persuasion exercises whose ethical standing depends on truthful content, transparent sponsorship and freedom from coercion rather than on the mere fact that a government is communicating.
- C. Persuasion respects audience autonomy and relies on truthful argument; manipulation exploits cognitive biases or asymmetric information while concealing intent; propaganda uses repetition and emotional framing at scale, often state-sponsored, to bypass critical evaluation rather than engage it.
- D. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself.

Answer: D Explanation: The same digital channel enables both legitimate persuasion and disinformation is the controlling principle. Social media raises a distinctive GS-IV dilemma because the same channel used for legitimate public information campaigns can be used for disinformation and political manipulation; the ethical test is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy rather than the technology itself. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A collector refuses to fast-track a ruling-party worker's land file because the application lacks statutory documents. She applies the same rule to an opposition supporter's file. Which type of attitude is she exercising and which is she bracketing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- B. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- C. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- D. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.

Answer: A Explanation: Moral attitude judges right and wrong; political attitude evaluates parties and power is the controlling principle. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

An officer openly criticises a welfare policy because it was announced by the opposition when they were in power, not because of any procedural or ethical deficiency. Which attitudinal category has improperly entered official conduct? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- B. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- C. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.
- D. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.

Answer: B Explanation: Moral attitude judges right and wrong; political attitude evaluates parties and power is the controlling principle. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

A senior IAS officer votes in a general election and privately discusses policy preferences with family members but never lets party preference influence file disposal. Has she violated the non-partisanship obligation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- B. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- C. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- D. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.

Answer: C Explanation: CCS Conduct Rules require behavioural non-partisanship, not mental blankness is the controlling principle. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A block development officer distributes pamphlets for a political party during office hours and uses official vehicles for rally logistics. Which specific Conduct Rules has he breached and what is the ethical basis of the prohibition? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- B. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.
- C. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- D. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.

Answer: D Explanation: CCS Conduct Rules require behavioural non-partisanship, not mental blankness is the controlling principle. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A secretary prepares a candid note advising against a proposed scheme on grounds of fiscal risk and legal infirmity, then implements the minister's final lawful decision. Is this constructive dissent or political disloyalty? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- B. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- C. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- D. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.

Answer: A Explanation: Policy awareness is duty, not partisanship is the controlling principle. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A district magistrate accelerates files of the ruling party's preferred contractors while delaying others, claiming she is merely implementing government priorities. Which test distinguishes lawful policy implementation from partisan conduct? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- B. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- C. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.
- D. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.

Answer: B Explanation: Policy awareness is duty, not partisanship is the controlling principle. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A sub-divisional magistrate records in a written note that a proposed demolition drive lacks mandatory notice under municipal law and may harm vulnerable residents. Is this principled objection or political obstruction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- B. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- C. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.
- D. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.

Answer: C Explanation: Moral objection to a lawful policy is not political attitude is the controlling principle. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

An officer opposes a policy solely because it was proposed by a party she personally dislikes, without citing any legal, procedural or public-interest ground. Which boundary between moral and political attitude has she crossed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Central Civil Services Conduct Rules 1964 restrict a government servant's participation in politics and demonstrations under Rule 5 and election canvassing under Rule 7, operationalising political neutrality; the obligation covers official conduct and public activity, not the private holding of a political opinion or the exercise of one's vote.
- B. A civil servant is expected to understand the political executive's policy priorities, brief ministers candidly including with unwelcome advice, and implement lawfully enacted policy faithfully; this becomes partisan only when the officer's personal preference for a party rather than law and record drives a discretionary decision.
- C. A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts; a political attitude is a stance toward a specific party, ideology or contest for power, which is by design partisan and does not claim universal applicability.
- D. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment.

Answer: D Explanation: Moral objection to a lawful policy is not political attitude is the controlling principle. An officer who raises a reasoned ethical or legal objection to an instruction in a reasoned written note is exercising moral judgement about propriety and legality, not political preference, provided the objection is framed in terms of law, rules and public interest rather than partisan alignment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A senior officer with decades of anti-corruption commitment remains silent when a powerful political figure pressures her during a transfer posting. Which concept explains why even a strong attitude did not translate into resistant behaviour? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- B. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- C. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- D. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.

Answer: A Explanation: Attitude strength improves but does not guarantee behavioural prediction is the controlling principle. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A newly recruited officer with only classroom exposure to integrity quickly abandons her stance under peer pressure to accept facilitation payments. Which feature of attitude strength explains her vulnerability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- B. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- C. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.
- D. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.

Answer: B Explanation: Attitude strength improves but does not guarantee behavioural prediction is the controlling principle. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A probationer initially treats a difficult rural posting as punishment but reframes it as a learning opportunity after field immersion and mentoring. Which aspect of the malleability principle is illustrated and what structural support made the shift possible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- B. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- C. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- D. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.

Answer: C Explanation: William James's teaching affirms attitude malleability, not determinism is the controlling principle. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A department tells drought-affected farmers that they can overcome water scarcity by changing their attitude. Which misapplication of the malleability principle does this represent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- B. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.
- C. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- D. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.

Answer: D Explanation: William James's teaching affirms attitude malleability, not determinism is the controlling principle. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A department installs CCTV and strict attendance monitoring; absenteeism drops immediately but returns to previous levels when cameras malfunction. Which limitation of purely institutional constraint does this illustrate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- B. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- C. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- D. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.

Answer: A Explanation: Persuasion-based reform is slower but more durable than rule-based constraint is the controlling principle. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A Mission Karmayogi behavioural-competency module uses simulation and case-based learning over six months, producing slower but lasting change in citizen-facing conduct. Which trade-off between persuasion and constraint is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- B. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- C. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.
- D. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.

Answer: B Explanation: Persuasion-based reform is slower but more durable than rule-based constraint is the controlling principle. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A foundation-course module sends probationers to live in a tribal settlement for a week, interact with families and document access barriers. Which attitudinal component does immersive experience target that a classroom lecture cannot reach? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- B. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- C. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.
- D. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.

Answer: C Explanation: Training must target affective, not only cognitive, component for durable change is the controlling principle. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A training institute tests officers only on their knowledge of anti-discrimination law and declares bias eliminated. Which gap in the ABC model does this assessment miss? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The proposition that a person can alter life by altering attitudes captures the malleability of attitude: it is not fixed temperament but a chosen, revisable stance that can be reshaped through reflection, training and experience; it must not be misread as claiming that attitude change alone mechanically determines outcomes.
- B. Attitude change through persuasion is slower and less certain than rule-based reform through binding institutional constraints, but more durable once internalised; over-reliance on institutional constraint without attitude change risks purely compliance-based conduct that reverts once monitoring relaxes.
- C. Attitudes held with high certainty, personal relevance and frequent rehearsal resist persuasion and predict behaviour better than weakly held attitudes; however, even strong attitudes can be overridden by intense situational pressure, making institutional safeguards necessary even for committed officers.
- D. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities.

Answer: D Explanation: Training must target affective, not only cognitive, component for durable change is the controlling principle. Civil-service training that targets only the cognitive component through lectures and manuals is insufficient for durable attitude change; simulation-based and case-based learning that engages the affective component through empathetic exposure is necessary to reshape long-held biases toward marginalised communities. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

During disability-certificate verification, an officer helps an applicant correct a curable document error and records the reasoned decision rather than mechanically rejecting the claim. Which mindset is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- B. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- C. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- D. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.

Answer: A Explanation: Positive mindset reads rules with their public purpose is the controlling principle. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A licensing clerk exploits an ambiguous clause to demand informal payment for processing a routine renewal that the applicant is entitled to receive. Which attitudinal stance toward rules makes this extraction possible? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- B. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- C. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.
- D. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.

Answer: B Explanation: Positive mindset reads rules with their public purpose is the controlling principle. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

During a communal tension incident a sub-divisional magistrate remains calm, verifies rumours before acting, deploys peace committees and communicates transparently with both communities. Which attitudinal quality prevents administrative paralysis? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- B. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- C. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- D. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.

Answer: C Explanation: Positive attitude under stress preserves judgement and citizen trust is the controlling principle. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A collector facing a flood emergency panics, issues contradictory orders and blames subordinates publicly. Which consequence of a negative attitude under stress is most damaging to the relief operation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- B. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.
- C. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- D. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.

Answer: D Explanation: Positive attitude under stress preserves judgement and citizen trust is the controlling principle. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A tehsildar consistently delays mutation applications from a scheduled caste hamlet while processing upper-caste applications promptly, even though the same rules apply. Which attitudinal component most likely drives the differential treatment? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- B. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- C. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- D. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.

Answer: A Explanation: Attitude toward vulnerable groups shapes discretionary service quality is the controlling principle. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A district sends a welfare officer to live in a tribal settlement for a week before her posting begins. Which component of attitude is this immersive intervention designed to reshape? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- B. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- C. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.
- D. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.

Answer: B Explanation: Attitude toward vulnerable groups shapes discretionary service quality is the controlling principle. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A municipal officer waives a mandatory safety inspection for a school run by a local dignitary, citing compassion for children. Which limit on positive interpretation has been crossed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- B. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- C. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.
- D. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.

Answer: C Explanation: Purposive interpretation avoids both literalism and arbitrary benevolence is the controlling principle. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A licensing authority mechanically rejects a renewal because one supporting document has a minor typographical error that does not affect eligibility. Which interpretive deficiency does the attitude-behaviour gap framework identify here? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from amplifying a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness during difficult situations.
- B. A field officer's negative attitude toward a beneficiary community, formed through biased social conditioning, can distort service delivery even where rules are formally neutral; training must therefore target the affective component through immersive exposure rather than relying on rule-knowledge alone.
- C. A positive mindset interprets rules and regulations with their public purpose in view, applying them to enable fair access and citizen welfare; a negative mindset treats rules chiefly as obstacles, sources of power or shields against responsibility, producing delay, denial and extraction.
- D. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment.

Answer: D Explanation: Purposive interpretation avoids both literalism and arbitrary benevolence is the controlling principle. A sound administrative reading of rules avoids obstructive literalism that denies citizens entitled services and arbitrary benevolence that bypasses mandatory conditions for favoured applicants; the positive mindset interprets with public purpose while remaining accountable to law, published criteria and equal treatment. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: Given below are three quotations of great thinkers. What do each of these quotations convey to you in the present context? 3-(b) "The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes." - William James (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording from locally held official PDF: books/mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, Q3(b). Widely attributed to William James but not traceable to his writings; popularised by Norman Vincent Peale (1952). Cross-ownership: primarily routed to Topics 06/07 (Indian/Western Moral Thinkers) in the PYQ ledger; this owner has a strong cross-link claim via the malleability-of-attitude concept in Basic Section 3.5 and 7.

Model solution

The proposition conveys that attitudes are not permanently fixed: conscious reflection, learning and repeated practice can reshape how a person evaluates situations and therefore how that person acts. In public service, this matters because an officer's attitude toward citizens, marginalised groups and difficult postings shapes the quality of discretionary service delivery.

A probationer initially treating a remote rural posting as punishment may, through field immersion, mentoring and feedback, come to recognise local knowledge, learn the language and redesign welfare-access procedures. The changed attitude does not alter material constraints by wish alone; it changes attention, effort and willingness to collaborate. Mission Karmayogi's behavioural-competency modules, which use simulation and case-based learning, institutionalise precisely this kind of targeted attitude reshaping.

The proposition must not become victim-blaming. Poverty, discrimination, administrative opacity and inadequate staffing cannot be solved by asking citizens or employees merely to think positively. Structural reform, lawful entitlements and institutional accountability remain indispensable.

There is also a provenance caution: the exact sentence is widely attributed to William James but is not traceable to his published writings; it was popularised by Norman Vincent Peale. The answer should analyse the proposition without inventing a James citation. The verdict is that reflective attitude change is a real ethical resource when paired with fair institutions and concrete action.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Given below are three quotations of great thinkers. What do each of these quotations convey...", precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in "Given below are three quotations of great thinkers. What do each of these quotations convey to you in the present context? 3-(b) "The greatest..."".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Analysis: Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in "Given below are three quotations of great thinkers. What do each of these quotations convey to you in the present context? 3-(b) "The greatest..."".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis ->

qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Given below are three quotations of great thinkers. What do each of these quotations convey...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and interaction. However, it has raised several ethical issues and challenges. Describe the key ethical dilemmas in this regard.

(Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording from locally held official PDF: books/mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, Q1(a). Cross-ownership: primarily routed to Topic 13 (Emerging Ethics: Technology, AI and Environment) in the PYQ ledger; this owner has a strong cross-link claim because social media is fundamentally an attitude-persuasion-at-scale problem transforming the Hovland-Yale audience variable.

Model solution

Social media raises several interconnected ethical dilemmas for public administration and society. First, privacy and data harvesting: platforms collect personal data at scale, often without meaningful informed consent, creating conflicts with the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023. Second, misinformation and deepfakes: algorithmically amplified false content can reshape public attitudes faster than corrections can reach the same audience. Third, echo chambers and polarisation: recommendation algorithms create self-reinforcing information environments that narrow deliberative capacity.

Fourth, addictive design: attention-capture mechanisms exploit cognitive vulnerabilities, raising questions about platform responsibility. Fifth, anonymity and accountability: online anonymity enables hate speech and communal incitement while weakening deterrence. Sixth, the state's own use of the same channel: government social-media campaigns that use emotionally manipulative messaging without disclosing sponsorship shade from legitimate persuasion toward propaganda.

The underlying ethical test, drawn from attitude-persuasion theory, is transparency of intent and respect for audience autonomy. Technology itself is ethically neutral; its governance requires content-moderation frameworks, algorithmic transparency mandates and due-process safeguards that distinguish legitimate public information from manipulation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires an executable decision on “In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and...”: separate facts from assumptions; map stakeholders, rights and vulnerabilities; identify legal thresholds and value conflicts; compare options and consequences; choose, implement and monitor.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and interaction. However, it has raised several ethical issues...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Fact/claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Decision analysis: Identify the affected stakeholder, right or duty, foreseeable benefit/harm and institutional authority. **Execution and qualification:** State the responsible actor, written step, timeline, protection/review safeguard and fallback if the assumption proves false.

Counter-position / limit: Efficiency, loyalty, compassion or aggregate benefit cannot excuse an unlawful act or serious rights breach; equally, formal compliance without communication, protection, monitoring and remedy can leave the ethical failure intact.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and interaction. However, it has raised several ethical issues...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, use one-sixth of the time for facts/assumptions and stakeholders; state non-negotiable legal/rights thresholds; compare three realistic options; select a lawful ethical course; finish with timeline, written reasons, consultation, protection, review and fallback.

How to improve this answer: For “In the present digital age, social media has revolutionised our way of communication and...”, replace the weakest generic option with a named actor, deadline, communication channel, review indicator and residual-risk response.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss why a positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant especially under conditions of stress.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand from 2020 GS-IV Q4(b), neutral rendering from the PYQ ledger (_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md line 291). Routed to this owner. Not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

A positive attitude is essential under stress because it preserves analytical judgement, prevents panic from compounding a crisis, and maintains citizen trust in the administration's competence and fairness. Stress narrows attention and tempts hasty, arbitrary action; a constructive mental orientation keeps the officer focused on evidence, lawful procedure and the welfare of affected persons.

During a flood emergency, for example, a collector with a positive attitude verifies damage reports before allocating relief, communicates uncertainty honestly rather than issuing false assurances, coordinates with district health and police teams, and records decisions for later review. A negative attitude under the same pressure may produce blame-shifting, contradictory orders and favouritism in distribution.

The positive attitude needed is not naive optimism. It is a disciplined evaluative stance that treats obstacles as problems to be solved within rules rather than excuses for inaction or arbitrariness. It aligns with the ABC model: the cognitive component frames the crisis as manageable, the affective component sustains empathy, and the behavioural component translates both into timely, fair action.

However, attitude alone is insufficient. Institutional support through clear SOPs, adequate staffing, transparent criteria and grievance mechanisms must close the attitude-behaviour gap so that the officer's positive orientation translates into consistent ethical conduct even when pressure intensifies.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss why a positive attitude is an essential...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss why a positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant especially under conditions...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Analysis: Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss why a positive attitude is an essential characteristic of a civil servant especially under conditions...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss why a positive attitude is an essential...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how to build a suitable attitude needed for a public servant.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand from 2021 GS-IV Q4(a), neutral rendering from the PYQ ledger (_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md line 308). Routed to this owner. Not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

Building a suitable attitude for public service requires targeting all three components of the ABC model systematically. The cognitive component is addressed through foundational training that explains constitutional values, citizens' rights, service-delivery standards and the ethical reasoning behind rules. The affective component requires experiential learning: field immersion in underserved communities, structured interaction with beneficiaries, and simulation exercises that generate empathy and discomfort with exclusion.

The behavioural component is built through supervised practice: handling real citizen grievances under mentorship, recording reasoned decisions, receiving feedback and correcting bias. Persuasion principles apply here: credible trainers with field experience are more effective than abstract lectures, and peer-group discussion strengthens internalisation.

Mission Karmayogi's iGOT platform institutionalises continuous learning by linking role-based competencies to behavioural modules. However, training exposure alone does not guarantee internalisation. Institutional reinforcement through transparent work routines, ethical leadership, accountability mechanisms and protection of honest officers is necessary to close the attitude-behaviour gap.

The process is ongoing, not a one-time induction event. Periodic refresher training, peer accountability and regular ethics review help prevent the gradual erosion of positive attitudes through cynicism, burnout or rationalisation of small compromises.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how to build a suitable attitude needed for...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how to build a suitable attitude needed for a public servant.”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Analysis: Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how to build a suitable attitude needed for a public servant.”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how to build a suitable attitude needed for...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how a positive and a negative mindset can lead to different interpretations of rules and regulations.

Source / ownership: Older routed demand from 2022 GS-IV Q2(a), neutral rendering from the PYQ ledger (_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md line 323). Routed to this owner. Not claimed as verbatim wording in this data file.

Model solution

A mindset shapes how an official sees the purpose of a rule. A positive mindset treats regulation as an instrument to secure fairness, safety and public trust; a negative mindset treats it chiefly as an obstacle, a source of discretionary power, or a shield against responsibility. The difference becomes ethical when interpretation affects citizens' rights and access.

A constructive officer reads a rule with its public purpose, applies it consistently and explains any refusal with reasons. A cynical officer may exploit ambiguity to delay service, demand informal payment or deny reasonable assistance by saying the file cannot move. During disability-certificate verification, a facilitative officer helps an applicant correct a curable document error and records the reasoned decision; a negative one mechanically rejects the claim despite available verification and no risk to legality. The former respects both rule and citizen dignity.

Positive interpretation is not permission to ignore mandatory conditions or grant favouritism. Compassion must operate within law, published criteria and equal treatment. The sound administrative stance is therefore purposive but accountable: it avoids both obstructive literalism and arbitrary benevolence, and keeps the citizen-government interface lawful, responsive and reviewable.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how a positive and a negative mindset can...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how a positive and a negative mindset can lead to different interpretations of rules and regulations.”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Analysis: Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how a positive and a negative mindset can lead to different interpretations of rules and regulations.”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Neutral rendering of the routed demand: Discuss how a positive and a negative mindset can...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: Neutral rendering of the cross-linked demand: Discuss the significance of Mission Karmayogi in building behavioural competencies and reshaping attitudes of civil servants toward citizen-centred governance.

Source / ownership: Cross-linked demand synthesised from 2024 GS-IV Q6(b) (Mission Karmayogi). Primarily routed to Topic 04 (Aptitude and Foundational Values); this owner contributes the attitude-formation and training-design angle. Not claimed as verbatim wording.

Model solution

Mission Karmayogi's National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building is significant for attitude reshaping because it shifts training focus from rules memorisation to role-based behavioural competencies at the citizen-government interface. This directly targets the cognitive and affective components of attitude through iGOT platform modules that use case studies, simulations and citizen-interaction scenarios.

The programme's approach reflects sound persuasion principles: credible trainers with field experience deliver contextualised content to a receptive audience of serving officers, using appropriate digital and classroom channels. The shift from rules-based to roles-based orientation means that an officer learns not just what a regulation says but how to apply it empathetically and fairly in diverse citizen-facing situations.

However, course completion statistics do not prove attitudinal internalisation. An officer may perform well on a module yet revert to old patterns under institutional pressure, peer norms or workload stress. The attitude-behaviour gap persists unless training is reinforced by ethical leadership, transparent work routines, citizen feedback mechanisms and protection of honest officers. Mission Karmayogi is therefore a valuable institutional channel for attitude change, not a certificate of ethical governance in every service setting.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Neutral rendering of the cross-linked demand: Discuss the significance of Mission Karmayogi...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the cross-linked demand: Discuss the significance of Mission Karmayogi in building behavioural competencies and reshaping...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Analysis: Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Neutral rendering of the cross-linked demand: Discuss the significance of Mission Karmayogi in building behavioural competencies and reshaping...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis ->

qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Neutral rendering of the cross-linked demand: Discuss the significance of Mission Karmayogi...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for ethical conduct in civil service. Illustrate with the concept of the attitude-behaviour gap. (Answer in 150 words) Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

A positive attitude provides a civil servant with constructive orientation toward duty, fairness and citizen welfare. It shapes how rules are interpreted, how crises are managed and how vulnerable persons are treated. In this sense it is necessary for ethical administration.

However, LaPiere's 1934 study established that stated attitudes predict specific behaviour poorly. An officer who sincerely values transparency may still withhold information when a superior exerts pressure, when career incentives discourage disclosure, or when institutional norms reward silence. This is the attitude-behaviour gap: situational forces and institutional design can override even strongly held positive attitudes.

For example, in a revenue department, officers may declare commitment to impartiality yet allow political recommendations to influence file disposal because the transfer-posting system punishes non-compliance. The gap closes only when institutional safeguards such as RTI mandates, audit trails, whistleblower protection and transparent criteria reinforce the positive attitude with binding external constraints.

The verdict is that attitude is the starting point of ethical conduct, but institutional design is its guarantor.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for ethical conduct in civil service. Illustrate with the concept of...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The verdict is that attitude is the starting point of ethical conduct, but institutional design is its guarantor. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for ethical conduct in civil service. Illustrate with the concept of...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis ->

qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Discuss why a positive attitude, though necessary, is not a sufficient condition for...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service training to reduce bias in service delivery. (Answer in 150 words) Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

The ABC model identifies cognitive, affective and behavioural components, each requiring a distinct training intervention to reduce bias.

The cognitive component is addressed through factual correction: presenting officers with evidence on entitlements, dispelling stereotypes about beneficiary communities, and explaining legal standards of non-discrimination. However, correcting beliefs alone is insufficient because bias often resides in the affective component.

The affective component requires experiential engagement: field immersion in tribal settlements, supervised interaction with persons with disabilities, and simulation exercises that generate empathy. Mission Karmayogi modules that use case-based learning target this layer. A probationer who lives in a rural community for a week develops emotional familiarity that a lecture cannot produce.

The behavioural component is shaped through supervised practice: handling real citizen grievances, receiving mentor feedback on interpersonal conduct, and being held accountable for service timelines. Transparent work routines and citizen satisfaction feedback reinforce the behavioural shift.

The trade-off is cost and time: affective training is slower and harder to scale. The verdict is that all three components must be targeted concurrently for bias reduction to be durable.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service training to reduce bias in service delivery. (Answer in 150...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The ABC model identifies cognitive, affective and behavioural components, each requiring a distinct training intervention to reduce bias. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The trade-off is cost and time: affective training is slower and harder to scale. The verdict is that all three components must be targeted concurrently for bias reduction to be durable. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and

review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service training to reduce bias in service delivery. (Answer in 150...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine how the three components of attitude can be targeted differently in civil-service...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Distinguish between moral attitude and political attitude with reference to the obligations of a civil servant under the Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964. Why must one be retained and the other bracketed? (Answer in 250 words) Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

A moral attitude is an evaluative stance toward what is right or wrong, grounded in ethical reasoning and applicable across contexts. A political attitude evaluates a specific party, ideology or contest for power. Both are attitudes in the ABC-model sense, but they serve fundamentally different roles in public office.

The Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964, operationalise this distinction. Rule 5 restricts participation in politics and demonstrations; Rule 7 restricts election canvassing. These rules implement the constitutional expectation, linked to Article 309, that a civil servant serves the permanent executive with non-partisanship. The same officer must serve successive, differently aligned elected governments; if political preference steered decisions, the neutrality that enables rotation would collapse.

Moral attitude must be actively retained. A civil servant is expected to judge right from wrong: refusing an improper instruction, applying rules impartially and reporting corruption. This moral judgement makes non-partisanship trustworthy rather than merely mechanical compliance.

Non-partisanship does not require political blankness of mind: private belief and the exercise of one's vote are not misconduct. Candid briefing of ministers is duty, not partisanship. A moral objection framed in law and public interest is principled dissent, not political obstruction.

The verdict is that moral attitude is the instrument of ethical decision-making; political attitude must be bracketed because its expression substitutes partisan preference for the public interest the office exists to serve.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Distinguish between moral attitude and political attitude with reference to the obligations...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Distinguish between moral attitude and political attitude with reference to the obligations of a civil servant under the Central Civil Services...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Distinguish between moral attitude and political attitude with reference to the obligations of a civil servant under the Central Civil Services...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish between moral attitude and political attitude with reference to the obligations...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Analyse how cognitive dissonance operates as an ethical risk multiplier in public administration. Suggest institutional mechanisms to interrupt the rationalisation pathway. (Answer in 250 words) Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Cognitive dissonance arises when an official's behaviour contradicts a held attitude. Festinger identifies three resolution paths: change the attitude, change the behaviour, or add a self-justifying cognition. The third path, rationalisation, is the ethical risk multiplier because it lets officials with sound values gradually normalise small compromises.

Consider an officer who values transparency but is directed to withhold a routine file under a stretched RTI exemption. She convinces herself the exemption is broader than it is. The discomfort resolves without changing the unethical behaviour. Over time, 'everyone does it' becomes 'it is harmless' becomes settled practice. Small facilitation payments rationalised once as unavoidable become customary, then deserved. This is how dissonance multiplies ethical risk.

Institutional mechanisms interrupt this pathway. Regular ethics review sessions let officers examine their own justifications under guided reflection. Transparent decision records make it harder to sustain private rationalisation when colleagues see the reasoning. Audit trails document actual exemption scope, preventing stretched interpretations from going unexamined. Whistleblower protection ensures that an officer who chooses the second path is not punished for principled objection. Rotation breaks the settled relationships that sustain rationalisation.

The verdict is that cognitive dissonance is not itself unethical but its rationalisation pathway, unchecked by institutional design, converts individual psychological resolution into systemic ethical erosion.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Analyse how cognitive dissonance operates as an ethical risk multiplier in public...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Analyse how cognitive dissonance operates as an ethical risk multiplier in public administration. Suggest institutional mechanisms to interrupt the...”.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The verdict is that cognitive dissonance is not itself unethical but its rationalisation pathway, unchecked by institutional design, converts individual psychological resolution into systemic ethical erosion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Analyse how cognitive dissonance operates as an ethical risk multiplier in public administration. Suggest institutional mechanisms to interrupt the...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Analyse how cognitive dissonance operates as an ethical risk multiplier in public...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Critically examine the ethical boundary between legitimate government persuasion campaigns and propaganda, with reference to social media's role in shaping public attitudes. Use Indian examples. (Answer in 250 words) Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The ethical boundary between persuasion and propaganda turns on three criteria drawn from attitude-change theory: truthfulness of content, transparency of sponsorship and respect for audience autonomy. When all three are present, a government campaign is legitimate persuasion; when any is systematically violated, the campaign drifts toward manipulation or propaganda.

Legitimate persuasion is visible in India's vaccination communication during the COVID-19 pandemic. ASHA workers, as credible local sources, delivered factual messages in vernacular languages through trusted community channels. The Hovland-Yale variables were operationalised transparently: source credibility, clear message content and audience-appropriate delivery. Swachh Bharat Mission's behaviour-change campaign similarly used wall paintings, community meetings and identified government sponsorship to shift sanitation attitudes.

Social media complicates this picture. Platforms operationalise the audience variable at unprecedented precision through algorithmic micro-targeting. A government social-media cell that uses undisclosed paid influencers, emotionally manipulative imagery and suppresses critical comments crosses the ethical boundary even if the underlying policy goal is legitimate. The IT Rules' due-diligence obligations and the DPDP Act, 2023, provide regulatory anchors but enforcement remains uneven.

The same digital channel that enables legitimate public health advisories also enables disinformation and deepfakes. A blanket ban on government social-media communication would sacrifice legitimate public information; unchecked use risks normalising propaganda. The ethical test must therefore be applied to each campaign individually.

There is a boundary case that illustrates the difficulty. A district administration running a fear-based anti-open-defecation campaign without disclosing sponsorship may achieve behaviour change while violating transparency and autonomy. The ends do not settle the ethics; the means must also be defensible.

The verdict is that persuasion-based governance is ethically legitimate and often necessary, but its digital-age application demands explicit transparency standards, algorithmic accountability and institutional restraint against the temptation to exploit the same tools of manipulation that the state has a duty to regulate.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on “Critically examine the ethical boundary between legitimate government persuasion campaigns...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Critically examine the ethical boundary between legitimate government persuasion campaigns and propaganda, with reference to social media's role in...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Critically examine the ethical boundary between legitimate government persuasion campaigns and propaganda, with reference to social media’s role in...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Critically examine the ethical boundary between legitimate government persuasion campaigns...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the proposition that attitude change through persuasion is necessary but insufficient for ethical administration, discussing both the promise and the limits of attitude-based reform versus institutional constraint. (Answer in 250 words) Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Attitude-based reform and institutional constraint are complementary strategies for ethical administration, each with distinctive strengths and limits.

Attitude change through persuasion is necessary because no institutional rule can observe every exercise of discretion. An officer’s evaluative disposition toward citizens, marginalised groups and public duty shapes how ambiguous situations are handled: whether a curable document error is helped or rejected, whether a whistle is blown or suppressed, whether a posting is treated as punishment or opportunity. William James’s insight about attitude malleability applies: training, mentoring, field immersion and ethical leadership can genuinely reshape how officials interpret their role. Mission Karmayogi’s behavioural-competency modules institutionalise this approach.

But persuasion is slower than regulation and its effects are fragile. LaPiere’s attitude-behaviour gap shows that sincere attitudes can be overridden by situational pressure, career incentives and peer norms. Cognitive dissonance theory warns that officials who begin with sound values can rationalise small compromises into settled corrupt practice. Therefore institutional constraints such as RTI mandates, transparent criteria, audit trails, whistleblower protection and enforceable codes of conduct are necessary to close the gap that attitude alone leaves open.

Over-reliance on institutional constraint, however, risks purely compliance-based conduct, the box-ticking behaviour that reverts once monitoring relaxes. A department that installs surveillance without values education may see absenteeism drop temporarily but return when cameras malfunction. The code-of-ethics versus code-of-conduct distinction is relevant: the former targets internalised commitment, the latter external compliance.

The reasoned verdict is that ethical administration requires both: persuasion to build durable internal commitment, and institutional constraint to catch the cases where even genuine commitment fails under pressure. Neither strategy alone is sufficient, and the administrator’s task is to calibrate both to the specific governance context.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Evaluate the proposition that attitude change through persuasion is necessary but...”, precise definitions, relevant thinker/theory or public-law boundary, named Indian evidence, objections or trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Evaluate the proposition that attitude change through persuasion is necessary but insufficient for ethical administration, discussing both the...”.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Attitude-based reform and institutional constraint are complementary strategies for ethical administration, each with distinctive strengths and limits. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion. **Analysis:** Connect concept or theory -> public role/institution -> stakeholder effect -> trust, rights or justice implication. **Qualification:** State the objection, competing duty, distributional effect, legal boundary, implementation risk or source/date/status limit.

Counter-position / limit: No quotation, single theory, statutory provision or favourable outcome is self-justifying; test conflicting duties, rights thresholds, foreseeable consequences, vulnerable stakeholders, institutional competence and review.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the ethical demand in “Evaluate the proposition that attitude change through persuasion is necessary but insufficient for ethical administration, discussing both the...”.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding every clause; define and state a thesis; organise four to seven points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; reserve the final minute for authority, rights, consequences, implementation and residual-risk limits.

How to improve this answer: For “Evaluate the proposition that attitude change through persuasion is necessary but...”, replace the weakest abstraction with one named thinker, constitutional value, provision, institution or verified case and state the objection, safeguard or limit it does not resolve.